Article

Vote, party, or protest: The influence of confidence in political institutions on various modes of political participation in Europe

Alexia Katsanidou[a,*] and Christina Eder[b]
[a]GESIS – Leibniz Institute for the Social Sciences, Unter Sachsenhausen 6-8, Cologne D–50667, Germany.
[b]GESIS – Leibniz Institute for the Social Sciences, PO Box 12 21 55, Mannheim, D–68072 Germany.
*Corresponding author.

Abstract Although the study of the relationship between political confidence and political participation has produced contradictory results thus far, it has established, nevertheless, that this relationship depends on the exact nature of the participation: voting, party engagement and protesting. On the basis of these findings, to further specify the nature of this relationship, we make a second distinction between confidence in representative and implementing institutions. We assume that context matters, so our multi-level approach includes individual level data from the 1999 to 2001 and 2008 to 2010 waves of the European Values Study (EVS), as well as national-level data. Our results show that different types of confidence in institutions have unique effects on these three modes of participation and that these findings hold over the last decade. While confidence in parliament is the key to the elite-driven modes of participation, grassroots-driven modes are triggered by a lack of confidence in the implementing institutions.
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Introduction

Political participation is a pre-requisite for a well-functioning democracy (Verba *et al*, 1995, p. 1), as well as for the legitimacy of the political system and policy-making (Dalton, 2008, p. 76). The most common, yet declining, mode of participation is voting, but it is not the only opportunity citizens have to voice their opinions. Political engagement includes different ways of influencing politics that have been characterized in the literature as institutionalized, elite-driven and conventional; or

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less institutionalized, grassroots-driven and unconventional (Barnes and Kaase, 1979; Inglehart, 1997). In this article, we use the terms *elite-driven* and *grassroots-driven* to refer to the different modes of participation. The former includes voting and party engagement, and the latter attending a lawful demonstration, boycotting a product, occupying a building and joining a strike.

Although a general theory of trust does not exist and notions and explanations vary, scholars agree that without a certain level of confidence in political institutions, neither society nor democracy can function (Easton, 1965; Mishler and Rose, 1997; Newton, 2001; Dalton, 2004; Kumlin and Rothstein, 2005; Keele, 2007; Lenard, 2008; Freitag and Bühlmann, 2009). The declining confidence in political institutions observed during the last decades (Pharr *et al*, 2000) is a reason to worry about liberal democracy, social order and governability. Citizens with low levels of political confidence could either withdraw completely from political life, which in turn means certain parts of society and their interests are no longer represented in the decision-making process, or they could engage in grassroots-driven behaviour to avoid or bypass unpopular institutions. Depending on which modes they adopt, violent outbreaks and social unrest could be a consequence.

We do not contest that the question concerning how political confidence influences political participation is of relevance, as the number of studies on this topic is large. Yet, previous studies have produced different results as to whether, and under which conditions, political confidence shapes the engagement of the different modes of participation.

To address this variation in results, we make a distinction between confidence in the legislature (lower house) as the main representative institution in a liberal democracy and confidence in the implementing institutions as the expression of the *Rechtstaat*. Therefore, we seek to uncover the role that confidence in the different types of political institutions plays in the willingness to participate in the public sphere through voting, engaging with political parties and protesting, and thus on the readiness of individuals to influence the decision-making process.

Our sets itself apart from previous publications in four important aspects. First, in contrast to some prior research (cf. Hooghe and Marien, 2013), we make a clear distinction between confidence in two different types of political institutions to disentangle previously undiscovered influences. Second, contrary to the existing research (cf. Norris *et al*, 2005), we analyse three modes of political participation at the same time. As we use identical models to test our hypotheses on these different modes of participation, we are able to detect 'between-mode' differences that previous political participation studies failed to examine. These two novelties can shed light on the ambiguous relationship between political confidence and political participation. Third, we employ the third and fourth waves of the European Values Study (EVS). This strategy allows us to test our hypotheses at two points in time, whereas other research has concentrated on one time period (cf. Marien *et al*, 2010).

Finally, our multi-level approach enables us to incorporate individual and context factors simultaneously. We estimate the effects of system variables on individual political behaviour to detect both within- and between-nation variations.

With respect to the structure of our article, first, we lay out the differences between the three modes of political participation – vote, party engagement and protest – and focus on how confidence in parliament and the implementing political institutions influence them. Second, we review the data and methods used to test our hypotheses. Third, we present empirical findings that show that confidence in parliament is critical to elite-driven participation, whereas a lack of confidence in the implementing institutions propels grasroots-driven participation. Finally, we discuss the results by linking them to the current political and scholarly debates.

Modes of Political Participation

Scholars agree that political participation plays a vital role in a well-functioning democracy (cf. Verba *et al*, 1995, p. 1; Putnam, 2000, p. 336) because without political participation, democracy would lack 'both its legitimacy and its guiding force' (Dalton, 2008, p. 76). Voting is the most widespread mode of participation in the public sphere (Putnam, 2000, p. 31) and the key political right in a democracy. Owing to its uniqueness, voting is treated as a distinct form of political participation (cf. Kriesi, 2008). In addition to voting, democratic systems provide other opportunities for citizen engagement. The main distinction among these opportunities are between institutionalized or elite versus non-institutionalized or grassroots-driven modes of political participation (Barnes and Kaase, 1979, Inglehart, 1997). This distinction is widely accepted in the political participation literature (Inglehart and Catterberg, 2002; Dalton, 2008; Marien *et al*, 2010).

Elite-driven modes of participation are organized by the political elite, and political parties play a significant role in shaping and facilitating this type of participation. Joining political parties and voluntary party work are the most common forms of citizen involvement. According to Norris *et al* (2012, p. 288), 'party membership is understood to be one of the most important standard indicators of traditional or conventional political participation, especially in Western European mass-branch parties'.

Grassroots-driven modes of participation challenge the political elite and/or aim to influence the political agenda (Inglehart, 1997). Various forms of non-violent protest including demonstrations, boycotts and occupations of buildings fall into this category. Although these protest modes of participation usually have been classified as unconventional, innovative or non-institutionalized, Newton and Montero (2007, p. 219), for instance, have found that these activities are now routine.

The Influence of Confidence in Political Institutions on Political Engagement

The literature on the causal relationship between confidence in political institutions and political engagement agrees on the causal direction from confidence to engagement,[1] yet, it produces diametrically opposed causal mechanisms – one focuses on the impact of confidence and the other on the lack of confidence, the positive and negative poles of the same measure.

The first causal mechanism asserts that confidence in political institutions has a positive effect on political engagement. Higher levels of confidence lead to higher levels of elite-driven participation such as voting and party engagement (Stokes, 1962; Almond and Verba, 1963). Citizens expressing confidence in their political system participate, as they believe their voices will be heard. Conversely, and because of a perceived loss of political efficacy, declining confidence in political institutions results in lower-political participation: citizens no longer believe that elite-driven modes will make a difference (Abravanel and Busch, 1975). This negative impact of declining political confidence on voting has been observed in lower turnout rates (Luks and Citrin, 1997). However, recent empirical investigations have shown contradictory findings regarding this causal mechanism. Looking at the impact of the positive and negative poles of confidence, Hooghe and Marien (2013) found that citizens with high confidence in various political institutions[2] are more likely to opt for elite-driven participation, whereas Stolle *et al* (2005) have indicated that low or no confidence in political institutions[3] hinders this kind of political engagement. Other studies, such as Norris (1999, p. 260), found no significant relationship between political confidence[4] and party activism.

The second causal mechanism claims that low confidence in institutions is associated with higher overall levels of political participation.[5] This argument posits that without major grievances, the individual sees no obvious reason to become politically active (Craig and Maggiotto, 1981). This attitude can translate into higher turnout to 'eject the rascals', but it mainly materializes through grassroots-driven modes of political engagement (Kaase, 1999)[6] that challenge the system even to the point of violence (Muller *et al*, 1982). This claim has been tested under varying conditions including high-political efficacy (Gamson, 1968, p. 48; Hooghe and Marien, 2013), regime versus incumbent-oriented measures of confidence (Hibbing and Theiss-Morse, 2002), elite versus citizen directed participatory acts (Inglehart, 1997) and the perception of misinformation (Tarrow, 2000). The results of these studies were contradictory and depended on a combination of explanatory factors; however, they all agreed that lower confidence in political institutions increases the likelihood of active participation. Only Christiansen (2014) has shown that both unsupportive citizens (low trust in parliament, politicians and political parties; with high-political empowerment) and satisfied citizens (high trust in parliament,

politicians and political parties; with high-political empowerment) engage in grassroots-driven modes of participation such as protest.

How to explain these contradictions? Hooghe and Marien (2013) demonstrated that the relationship between confidence in political institutions and political participation depends on the exact nature of the participation – on whether we are considering more elite- or more grassroots-driven modes of participation. Continuing on this track and taking this reasoning one step further, this present article claims that this relationship also depends on the exact nature of the political institution. Assuming that it is not only the mode of participation but also the type of institution that matters, one reason for the contradictory findings might be in the mixture of representative, implementing and partisan institutions – and even occasionally international institutions – employed to operationalize political confidence. Therefore, we presume that confidence in political institutions is not unidimensional (Hooghe, 2011) but also is influenced by the nature of institutions in which people are asked to place their confidence. Political confidence expresses citizens' attitudes towards institutions (Catterberg and Moreno, 2006, p. 34), which indicates a belief that the 'authorities will observe the rules of the game and serve the general interest' (Citrin and Muste, 1999, p. 465). Tossing different institutions in one bowl might obscure the underlying-causal mechanisms.

Several institutions are important to the shaping of political confidence, and they can be divided into representative and implementing institutions (Denters *et al*, 2007; Rothstein and Stolle, 2008). *Representational political institutions* include any institutions with members elected by the public and whose elected officials are expected to act according to their ideology. Examples of such institutions are the parliament and the government at all levels of the state. As they can be characterized as partisan, confidence in them is connected to individual political attitudes. Also, confidence in the basic mechanism of representative institutions functions through evaluations of performance, political responsiveness, the representation of one's preferred party in government and voter's ideology. Consequently, citizens who support the ideology of the governing party or parties are more likely to place confidence in parliament and government, whereas the opposite is true for citizens holding opposing ideological views (Rudolf and Evans, 2005). *Implementing political institutions*, on the other hand, deal with policy implementation at different echelons, which include the civil service, police and various social service institutions. They are crucial for creating and maintaining trust, and are fundamental for democratic legitimacy (Rothstein and Stolle, 2003). Confidence in the implementing political institutions is connected to their efficiency, impartiality and fairness (Rothstein and Teorell, 2008), and thus a satisfaction with the way democracy works in a country, regardless of which political party or individuals govern. In particular, order and enforcement institutions, like the police, play a protective role 'taking care of people who are better not to be trusted' (Rothstein and Stolle, 2008). Confidence in implementing institutions implies that citizens do not feel obliged to take special

care for the well-functioning of the state, as they believe that these institutions work efficiently and adhere to the rule of law. In theory, confidence in representative and implementing institutions has similar but not identical origins. A separate accounting of them enables their effects to be disentangled and offers insights into how they affect political engagement. Previous empirical studies have found that confidence in implementing institutions was higher than confidence in representative institutions in the Western democracies and that this confidence varied across countries (Denters *et al*, 2007, p. 69). Also, these fluctuations did not always follow similar patterns. While confidence remained stable in some countries, others may have experienced significant changes (Torcal, 2014).

The present article focuses on the connection between confidence in parliament as the main representative institution, the civil service and police as the central implementing institutions, and the three modes of political engagement – voting, party engagement and protesting. Legislatures are central to representation in a democratic system. They enable various voices to be heard and to coexist. The role of parliament in a democratic system includes legislating policy output, but also parliament functions as a checks-and-balances mechanism for government. Unlike the executive, parliament represents all citizens and reflects different views within a society. It also serves as the link between the represented and the representative, and is the equivalent of interpersonal trust in a modern society (Seligman, 1997). As such, it is the key institution in democratic politics (Pharr *et al*, 2000). Expressing confidence in parliament as a political institution means believing it will fulfil its role. We expect citizens who express confidence in parliament to be more likely to use the representational mechanism of elections. We hypothesize that *higher levels of confidence in parliament have a positive effect on the likelihood to vote* (Hypothesis 1a, Table A1).

Similarly, political parties link citizens and the state. They 'organize democracy' (Dalton *et al*, 2011) to enable representation. Thus, high levels of confidence in parliament are important, as confidence in political institutions is associated with the willingness to grant the authority to legislate to the state (Hetherington, 1998). Parliament's role of channelling ideology into legislation would be impossible without political parties. Citizens who are members of or work for parties tend to be more positive towards the political system (Anderson *et al*, 2005); they are confident that parliament fulfils its role to inspire citizens to engage and to channel their voices into the legislative arena. Consequently, higher confidence in parliament should foster higher-citizen engagement with political parties. We hypothesize that *higher levels of confidence in parliament have a positive effect on the likelihood of citizens to engage with political parties* (Hypothesis 1b, Table A1).

Despite existing literature that indicates that low confidence leads to higher-grassroots-driven modes of participation, recent findings have demonstrated that citizens with and without confidence in parliament have an equal tendency to protest (Christiansen, 2014). This argument suggests that citizens with higher confidence in parliament believe that their grassroots participation will be heard and impact policymaking.

Thus, we hypothesize *that higher levels of confidence in parliament increase the likelihood of citizens to engage with protest behaviour* (Hypothesis 1c, Table A1).

Confidence in the implementing institutions like the civil service and police is central to perceptions of living in a well-functioning state. It shapes citizens' perception of equality before the law, safety and security. Thus, voting should suffice. Confidence in the implementing institutions should increase the likelihood of voting. We hypothesize that *higher levels of confidence in implementing institutions have a positive effect on the likelihood of citizens to vote* (Hypothesis 2a, Table A1).

We assume to find no effect of confidence in implementing institutions and party engagement on our dependent variables. As a representative institution, parties are the pillars of parliament, and thus belong to a different sphere than the civil service or police. For that reason there are no expectations that confidence in the one type of institution will transfer to the other type. (Hypothesis 2b, Table A1).

Having low or no confidence in the implementing political institutions can be seen as a reason to become more engaged in politics. Low confidence in the implementing institutions goes with the belief that the political system is malfunctioning, and leads to a feeling of discrimination and injustice. Citizens with no confidence in the implementing institutions are more likely to engage in protest activities. We hypothesize *lower levels of confidence in implementing institutions increase the engagement of citizens in protest behaviour* (Hypothesis 2c, Table A1).

Figure A1 shows how often the three different modes of participation – voting, party engagement and protest – are used in different European countries. The numbers are average percentages at the country level from the EVS 2008 (EVS, 2011b), which is the most recent wave of this particular study. *Party engagement* refers to working for a party and/or being a party member; *protesting* is operationalized through participating in a lawful demonstration, engaging in a boycott, joining an unofficial strike and/or occuping a building or factory.[7] Countries are rank-ordered by mean levels of confidence in parliament, from low to high. We see a considerable between-country variation in all three modes of participation. Unsurprisingly, voting is the most often cited mode of participation. The number of respondents identifying themselves as party members or party volunteers is relatively low in all countries, yet differences exist across borders. Protesting often is used in some countries, and less in others. As levels of trust in parliament rise, a very small increase in reported voting and party engagement seems to occur, but several outliers also exist. Figure A1 shows that the multi-level approach we chose is valid for researching the effects of confidence on participation.

Data and Research Design

To test our hypotheses, we use the integrated data sets of the third and fourth wave of the EVS (EVS, 2011a, b) conducted between 1999–2001 and 2008–2010.

The non-European Union (EU) and non-European Free Trade Association members were deleted to achieve a Most-Similar-Systems-Design. The result is a database containing about 43 000 (33 000) interviews covering 30 (27) West, Central and East European countries in 2008 (1999). Owing to (systematic) missing data on level-1 variables and the desire to analyse the same countries in both waves, the number of respondents in the sample was later reduced to roughly 15 000 in 2008 (about 12 000 in 1999) in 19 countries. A comparison of the two EVS waves was done by estimating separate models for each dependent variable for each of the two waves. This strategy enabled us to disentangle the decade-effects that would be harder to detect if we estimated pooled models. By doing so, we also accounted for the variations in the questions wording observed between the waves (see endnote *ix*). We employed hierarchical logistical models to simultaneously estimate the effects of individual *and* national characteristics on the different modes of political participation. The final models use random intercepts to better fit the structure of the data.

Measurement of dependent variables[8]

We ran models for three dependent variables: voting, engaging with political parties and protesting. *Voting* is a dimension of its own: *Participating in an election* is a different level of engagement and commitment than being a party member or volunteer for a party, so we incorporated participation in an election as a single variable.[9] If an individual expresses her/his willingness to participate in the next general election, he/she is assigned a value of 1, if not then a value of 0. We expect this measure to be much higher than the actual turnout; it captures the plan of a person to vote at a given point in time but not their actual behaviour. Unfortunately, it is the only item on turnout available in the data set. *Party engagement* is an additive measure combining party membership and volunteer work for political parties.[10] Both are dummy variables indicating whether an individual is currently a member of a political party and/or has ever done volunteer work for a political party. If individuals report to have done neither, they are assigned a value of 0; if at least one measure was taken, they receive a value of 1. *Protesting* is an additive variable as well. A value of 1 is assigned to a person reporting to either having joined a boycott, attended a lawful demonstration, joined an unofficial strike and/or occupied a building or factory.[11] A value of zero is given otherwise.[12]

Measurement of the independent variables

Political confidence is broken down into confidence in parliament and confidence in implementing institutions. For *confidence in parliament*, we used the question on confidence in parliament.[13] *Confidence in implementing institutions* is a composite measure encompassing confidence in the police and the civil service. The result is an

index that, like confidence in parliament, ranges from 0 to 4 with 0 indicating that the respondent has no confidence in any of the two institutions, and 4 meaning that they have a great deal of trust in both.

We incorporated control variables into our models that have proven to be influential before: political attitudes, political interest, social trust and socio-demographics. Political attitudes affect the willingness to become politically active and the choice of the means to do so. We looked at *left–right self-placement, post-materialism* and *satisfaction with* and *support for democracy*. Traditionally, right-leaning individuals tend to support the preservation of the status quo, whereas leftists 'are more likely to challenge the political status quo' (Dalton *et al*, 2009, p. 60). Therefore, placing oneself more on the left is linked to protest behaviour. Likewise, post-materialist attitudes are associated with innovative modes of participation, as they 'fit the self-expressive norms of engaged citizens, more so than participation in elections' (Dalton, 2008, p. 85). Items on political attitudes were rescaled to start with a value of 0. Citizens satisfied with the democratic system are likely to comply with the rules and make use of the elite-driven decision-making mechanisms. We constructed an *index capturing how 'democratic' a respondent is*, meaning, how they evaluate the different options of governing. Respondents were asked whether they believed democracy to be the best-political system, whether they preferred the army or a strong leader to rule the country, or whether they preferred experts to make the government decisions. Answers were added up so that higher values indicate a stronger preference for democracy. We assumed that supporters of democracy use all three modes of participation more than supporters of other ways of governing.

Further control variables include *interest in politics, social trust and socio-demographics*. Interest in politics is considered a pre-requisite for understanding political behaviour and is expected to have a positive impact on all the tested modes of participation (for example, Gamson, 1968, p. 48; Bandura, 1982). Social trust is based on a question about general trust in people[14] and has a binary coding with 0 standing for 'can't be too careful' and 1 'most people can be trusted.' The socio-demographic variables included in our analysis are education, age, gender and social capital. To measure social capital, a dichotomous variable captured whether a respondent answered *yes* on at least one of the 'do you belong to …' questions.[15] A value of 0 is given otherwise. Party membership and religious affiliation were not considered when building the index. According to resource theory, people with more resources engage more in political action. Thus, we expected education and social capital to have a positive impact on every mode of political action.

The impact of context

Citizens' political participation cannot be understood outside their political context. They are clustered in countries with different political traditions, levels of political

maturity and legal frameworks. In the present study, we controlled for the impact of the political context on political participation. The most important characteristic is the rule of law, which is understood as the 'perceptions of the extent to which agents have confidence in and abide by the rules of society' (Kaufmann *et al*, 2010, p. 4). When these rules are not followed by citizens or politicians, institutions are degenerated, and corruption thrives and the levels of political confidence should be low (DellaPorta, 2000; Morris and Klesner, 2010, p. 21). Such systems tend to be unreliable in the sense that citizens cannot predict policy outcomes and are left not knowing what to expect (van der Meer and Dekker, 2011, p. 98). In these cases, citizens tend to express low confidence in the system, and turn to more grassroots-driven modes of participation like protest. Thus, the rule of law influences the likelihood of citizens to engage in the political sphere.

Rules of the political game such as the proportionality of the electoral system also can influence political participation. Each type of electoral system has a different way of integrating individual policy preferences into policymaking, which is closely related to the Lijphart school of measuring democracy (Lijphart, 1999). A consensual democratic system provides more access points to the decision-making process, and thus a more favourable opportunity structure for political participation than majoritarian systems. With respect to electoral systems, research shows that turnout under proportional representation is higher because fewer votes are 'lost' when distributing seats in parliament (Geys, 2006; Norris, 2011, p. 222). A higher chance of being a 'winner' should further citizens' willingness to participate using more elite-driven modes. A higher chance of being a 'loser' should, in contrast, heighten citizens' readiness to use more grassroots-driven forms of participation to have their voice heard in the decision-making process. This outcome should at least be true for majoritarian systems because 'losers in the systems that are more consensual display higher levels of satisfaction with the way democracy works than do losers in systems with majoritarian characteristics' (Anderson and Guillory, 1997, p. 66). Information about proportionality is from Armingeon *et al* (2011) and the rule of law information is from the World Bank measure (Kaufmann *et al*, 2010).

Another factor influencing voter turnout is electoral closeness measured as the difference in the vote percentage between the largest and second largest party in government and is included into the models.[16] The expectation that this measure will have an effect on our dependent variables has two main foundations: it increases the feeling that every vote counts, and simultaneously, political parties and candidates increase their voter mobilization efforts (Fauvelle-Aymar and Abel, 2006).

Empirical Results and Discussion

A first look at our results shows that confidence in political institutions is very important for understanding the political engagement of citizens in the European

democracies under analysis. However, not all types of confidence are important for all modes of participation and, as expected, the direction of the impact varies. In terms of hypotheses testing, five out of six hypotheses are supported by our results at both points in time. For one hypothesis, our results were inconclusive.

Tables A2 and A3 provide empirical findings for 1999 and 2008. Our voting-related hypotheses Hypothesis 1a and Hypothesis 2a are supported as the likelihood to turn out to vote increases for individuals expressing confidence in parliament and the implementing institutions. With respect to party engagement, we find both hypotheses supported: confidence in parliament increases the chances of citizens being a member of and/or working for a party (Hypothesis 1b). The coefficients for confidence in the implementing institutions and party engagement (Hypothesis 2b) are insignificant and very small, which supports the non-effect hypothesis.

As expected, the likelihood of engaging with protest behaviour increases with a lack of confidence in the implementing institutions (Hypothesis 2c). Our expectation for Hypothesis 1c was that confidence in parliament has positive effects on the probability to protest. Yet, only our 1999 findings support our hypothesis, whereas in 2008, confidence in parliament loses its statistical significance altogether, and the coefficient becomes very small. This result shows that confidence in parliament as the key representative institution plays no consistent significant role in the decision to engage in protest behaviour. Even citizens who believe parliament is functioning well can find reasons to protest. One possible explanation is that protest most often is a single-issue activity: people demonstrate against a policy, decision or proposition of relevance to them, or they decide (not) to buy a product. Confidence in parliament, however, is a more general evaluation of the functioning of the institution and, more or less explicitly, of democracy as a whole. As a consequence, confidence in parliament and protesting could be unrelated, which is reflected by our 2008 result.

The results for Hypothesis 2c are also in line with the literature, which connects low political confidence to grassroots-driven modes of political engagement (cf. Inglehart, 1997; Kaase, 1999; Hooghe and Marien, 2013). These results also show that a lack of confidence in the implementing institutions undermines the perception of living in a well-functioning state and is the key to protest behaviour.

Most individual control variables behaved as expected and as stated in the literature. Social trust is significant for protesting in both years but also for voting in 2008. Political interest increases the chances of using all three modes of participation, and being left-wing and holding post-materialist attitudes heighten the likelihood of protest activities. People satisfied with democracy turn out to vote more often and protest less, although the 1999 coefficient is not significant. People preferring democracy over other ways of governing use all modes of participation more often than people who favour strong rulers, the military or experts to govern; however, some coefficients are insignificant. More educated respondents are more likely to vote, but less educated people do not use protest modes more often. In fact, the contrary is true. Men are more likely to protest and engage with a party. Meanwhile,

social capital facilitates all three modes. With respect to unemployment, we find the expected lower likelihood to vote, although the coefficient is insignificant in 1999. With respect to protest, the results are inconclusive.

Regarding our context factors, we found that most are statistically insignificant. The rule of law showed the expected strong and positive influence on turnout, but only in 1999. In 2008, it seems less important, maybe because the citizens of the EU-member states had, overall, experienced a comparably long period of regime stability. It will be interesting to compare these results to data in the next EVS wave in 2017, which will include the political and social unrest in the aftermath of the euro crisis. In 2008, even more so than in 1999, the rule of law asserted a positive influence on protesting. One explanation for this finding could be that when a more politically educated and active citizenry puts faith in the political opportunity structure of a modern and stable democracy, political protest can occur without risking one's life. The proportionality of the electoral system and the closeness of the electoral competition did not have a significant effect on any of the three modes of participation.

Conclusion

This article relates to the ongoing scientific and public debate about the allegedly dissatisfied and distrustful citizens who stay away from the polls, and the rising numbers of protests against government policies in Europe. We tested the impact of confidence in political institutions on the various modes of political participation by disentangling the effects of confidence in the representative and implementing institutions. We found confidence in parliament is the key for the elite-driven political engagement. The driving force for grassroots-political engagement is low confidence in the implementing institutions. These results are the first attempt to demonstrate that the relationship between political participation and confidence in political institutions depends not only on the exact nature of the participation act (Hooghe and Marien, 2013) but also on the exact nature of the political institution.

Our findings contribute to the debate on the relationship between confidence in institutions and political participation in three ways. First, they open up the debate on the dimensionality of confidence in the different kinds of political institutions. Previous literature produced inconclusive results, and a closer look at these studies showed that each chose a different set of institutions or a mixture of confidence in institutions questions and other related items. These contradictory results on the relationship between confidence in political institutions and political engagement might be attributed to the variation in the operationalization of political confidence and the inclusion of different institutions in the construction of the political confidence index. Denters *et al* (2007) analysed the diverging nature of various types of political institutions along these lines, and the results of our article open a way to

re-think the dimensionality of confidence in political institutions, at least to the extent that it influences political participation. Upon finding that even satisfied citizens protest, Christiansen (2014) concluded that protest is not necessarily a sign for low-democratic legitimacy. Considering the impact of confidence in implementing institutions on protest, future research should be more cautious regarding such optimism.

Second, we show that space and time do not play a significant role in political participation in Europe. The effects of confidence in the various types of political institutions are mostly stable, at least for two points in time – 1999 and 2008. With the exception of the rule of law, the statistical insignificance of systemic variables makes it clear that for the countries incorporated in our analyses, context plays a minimal role in shaping political participation. Again, a possible explanation is the stability that EU countries experience in comparison with other countries worldwide. The MSS-design we chose might also play a role. It will be interesting to see whether and how our results change once the EVS 2017 data is available, which covers the financial crisis and its aftermath.

Finally, with respect to the quality of democracy and citizen alienation, based on our findings, the often cited constant decline in confidence in political institutions (Pharr *et al,* 2000) would result in lower-elite-driven and higher-grassroots-driven political engagement. To counteract feelings of political alienation and the related negative side effects, policymakers should work to improve the sense of equality that is derived from the successful functioning of the implementing institutions, and the sense of representation derived from the successful functioning of the representative institutions.

About the Authors

Alexia Katsanidou is the Director of the Data Archive at GESIS – Leibniz Institute for the Social Sciences (Germany). Her research focuses on individual political behaviour, party politics and representation in European and EU politics. Her work has been published among others in *European Union Politics, West European Politics* and *Acta Politica.* She is currently working on the radicalization of European societies and the change of dimensionality of political space because of the crisis. In addition, she works on the topic of researcher incentives for data sharing.

Christina Eder is Senior Research Associate and Head of the Research Data Center Elections at GESIS – Leibniz Institute for the Social Sciences (Germany). Her research focuses on electoral and non-electoral political participation, in particular direct democracy and elections, gender politics, and the measurement and effects of political institutions. Her work has appeared in *West European Politics, Parliamentary Affairs, Politische Vierteljahresschrift* and *Politische Psychologie.* She also is a

co-editor of a volume on political trust and disenchantment with politics published with Brill.

Notes

1 The direction of causality runs from attitudes to behaviour. However, behaviour can influence attitudes, and thus confidence in political institutions. For example, Hooghe and Kern (2015) identified a weak influence of party membership on political trust. However, to disentangle this causal direction, panel data are needed that are not available, and thus this endeavour remains beyond the scope of this article.
2 They use parliament, legal system, police, politicians and political parties.
3 They use politicians, police officers, business, national government and the United Nations.
4 They use parliament, civil service, legal system, parties and government.
5 See the discussion in Levi and Stoker (2000, pp. 486–488).
6 He uses the legal system, press, police, parliament and civil service.
7 For more information, see Section 4. Signing a petition is sometimes characterized as 'innovative' or 'non-institutionalized.' We excluded *petition signing* from the EVS questionnaire, as it is not clear what exactly is meant by the term: a non-binding request to parliament to deal with a certain matter, the first stage of a popular initiative or optional referendum as part of the law-making process, or a collection of signatures to raise awareness about a certain topic like human rights abuse or the protection of the environment.
8 We ran tests for the invariance of measurements, and the results did not indicate any problems.
9 For voting in the third wave, we raised the question: 'Which party are you planning to vote for in the upcoming election?' 'I will not vote' was coded as 0, all respondents that gave the name of a party were coded 1. In 2008, the question was the following: 'If there was a general election tomorrow, can you tell me if you would vote?' which was coded yes (1) or no (0). These differences might influence the comparability of the questions, but as the EVS does not contain other items on electoral participation, and as we do not pool the data and analyse both waves separately, we nevertheless decided to use these two.
10 Questions used: 'Please look carefully at the following list of voluntary organizations and activities and say … (a) which, if any, do you belong to? – political parties/groups' and 'Please look carefully at the following list of voluntary organizations and activities and say which, if any, are you currently doing unpaid voluntary work for? – political parties/groups'.
11 Questions used: 'Now I'd like you to look at this card. I'm going to read out some different forms of political action that people can take, and I'd like you to tell me, for each one, whether you have actually done any of these things, whether you might do it, or would never, under any circumstances, do it. – joined a boycott, – attended a lawful demonstration, – joined an unofficial strike, or – occupied a building or factory'.
12 The third and fourth wave of the EVS do not contain items on other protest modes of participation.
13 Question used: 'Please look at this card and tell me, for each item listed, how much confidence you have in them; is it a great deal, quite a lot, not very much, or none at all? – Parliament'.
14 Question used: 'Generally speaking, would you say that most people can be trusted or that you can't be too careful in dealing with people?'.
15 Questions used: 'Please look carefully at the following list of voluntary organizations and activities and say … (a) which, if any, do you belong to?' and 'Please look carefully at the following list of voluntary organizations and activities and say which, if any, are you currently doing unpaid voluntary work for?'.
16 We thank our reviewer for this important comment.

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Appendix

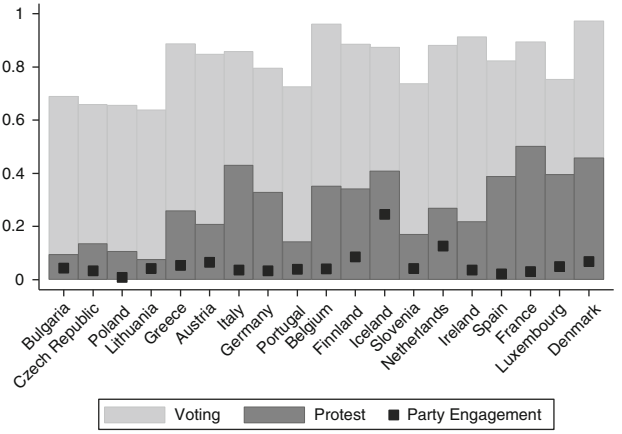


Figure A1: Political participation ordered by 'confidence in parliament' from the lowest (Bulgaria) to the highest (Denmark).
Source: EVS 2008 (EVS, 2011b).

Table A1: Influence of confidence on modes of political engagement

	Voting	*Party engagement*	*Protest*
Confidence in parliament	Positive (Hypothesis 1a)	Positive (Hypothesis 1b)	Positive (Hypothesis 1c)
Confidence in implementing institutions	Positive (Hypothesis 2a)	No effect (Hypothesis 2b)	Negative (Hypothesis 2c)

Table A2: Political participation 1999

	Voting	*Party engagement*	*Protesting*
Intercept	–0.01 (0.70)	–8.83 (0.83)**	–1.42 (0.60)*
Alternative participation			
Voting	—	1.12 (0.22)**	–0.04 (0.06)
Party engagement	1.20 (0.22)**	—	0.13 (0.08)
Protesting	–0.03 (0.07)	0.12 (0.08)	—
Individual level			
Confidence in parliament	0.34 (0.05)**	0.26 (0.06)**	0.12 (0.03)**
Confidence in implementing institutions	0.16 (0.05)**	–0.07 (0.07)	–0.20 (0.04)**
Social trust	–0.09 (0.07)	–0.02 (0.08)	0.17 (0.04)**
Interest in politics	0.55 (0.04)**	0.99 (0.05)**	0.38 (0.03)**
Self-placement left	0.42 (0.07)**	0.03 (0.08)	0.67 (0.04)**
Satisfaction w/democracy	0.27 (0.04)**	–0.06 (0.05)	–0.04 (0.03)
Democratic index	0.02 (0.02)	0.05 (0.02)**	0.07 (0.01)**
Post-materialism	0.00 (0.09)	0.08 (0.09)	0.40 (0.05)**
Education	0.02 (0.06)	0.05 (0.06)	0.24 (0.04)**
Age	0.01 (0.00)**	0.02 (0.00)**	–0.01 (0.00)**
Gender (Male)	–0.09 (0.06)	0.33 (0.07)**	0.17 (0.04)**
Social capital	0.16 (0.06)*	0.79 (0.09)**	0.44 (0.05)**
Unemployment	–0.16 (0.11)	–0.04 (0.20)	0.19 (0.09)*
Country level			
Proportionality	–0.03 (0.64)	1.16 (0.72)	–0.72 (0.54)
Electoral closeness	–0.01 (0.01)	0.00 (0.01)	0.01 (0.01)
Rule of law	0.65 (0.27)*	0.07 (0.29)	0.18 (0.22)
Random terms			
Var $(u_0) = \tau_{00}$	0.35	0.41	0.25
χ^2 (df)	311.6 (15)**	316.5 (15)**	488.3 (15)**
N (Individuals)	12249	12249	12249
N (Countries)	19	19	19

Notes: * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$. Standard errors in parantheses. All models calculated with HLM 6 using a restricted maximum likelihood estimation. Logit coefficients are reported. All values are rounded to two decimals. df – degrees of freedom.

Table A3: Political participation 2008

	Voting	*Party engagement*	*Protesting*
Intercept	–0.05 (0.80)	–8.86 (0.75)**	–0.66 (0.64)
Alternative participation			
Voting	—	0.76 (0.18)**	0.05 (0.06)
Party engagement	0.82 (0.18)**	—	0.42 (0.07)**
Protesting	0.06 (0.06)	0.37 (0.07)**	—
Individual level			
Confidence in parliament	0.16 (0.04)**	0.20 (0.05)**	–0.02 (0.03)
Confidence in implementing institutions	0.11 (0.04) *	0.05 (0.06)	–0.19 (0.03)**
Social trust	0.22 (0.06)**	–0.09 (0.07)	0.21 (0.04)**
Interest in politics	0.66 (0.03)**	1.12 (0.05)**	0.39 (0.02)**
Self-placement left	0.20 (0.06)**	–0.01 (0.07)	0.74 (0.04)**
Satisfaction w/democracy	0.30 (0.04)**	–0.00 (0.05)	–0.14 (0.03)**
Democratic index	0.00 (0.01)	0.03 (0.02)	0.03 (0.01) *
Post-materialism	0.03 (0.08)	–0.03 (0.08)	0.41 (0.05)**
Education	0.04 (0.06)	–0.04 (0.07)	0.37 (0.04)**
Age	0.01 (0.00)**	0.01 (0.00)**	–0.01 (0.00)**
Gender (Male)	–0.07 (0.05)	0.17 (0.07) *	0.13 (0.04)**
Social capital	0.44 (0.06)**	1.42 (0.09)**	0.47 (0.04)**
Unemployment	–0.28 (0.10)**	–0.02 (0.19)	–0.02 (0.09)
Country level			
Proportionality	–0.75 (0.80)	1.05 (0.70)	–1.30 (0.64)
Electoral closeness	–0.15 (0.60)	0.01 (0.01)	0.02 (0.01)
Rule of law	0.01 (0.01)	–0.14 (0.26)	0.52 (0.24) *
Random terms			
Var $(u_0) = \tau_{00}$	0.57	0.42	0.37
χ^2 (df)	642.6 (15)**	370.5 (15)**	724.5 (15)**
N (Individuals)	15410	15410	15410
N (Countries)	19	19	19

Notes: * p <0.05, ** p <0.01. Standard errors in parantheses. All models calculated with HLM 6 using a restricted maximum likelihood estimation. Logit coefficients are reported. All values are rounded to two decimals. df – degrees of freedom.

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